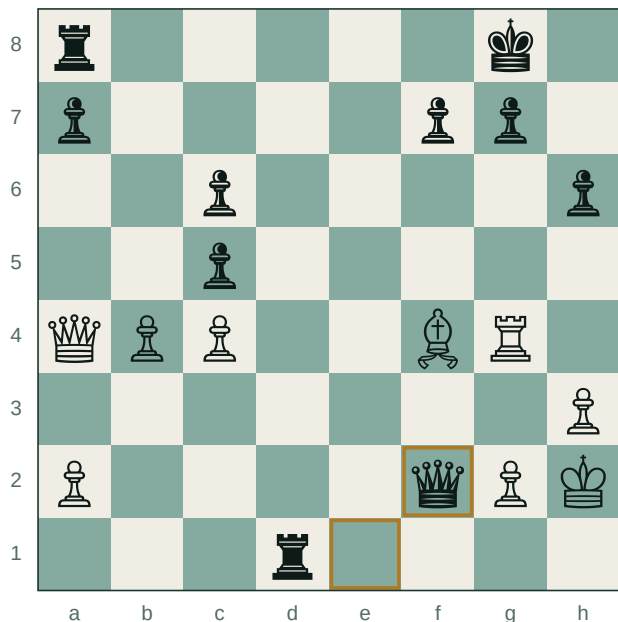


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 29

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 28...Qxf2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

29. Qxd1 h5 30. Bg3

29.Qxd1 The queen captures the rook on d1. Recorded reply: **29...h5**.

30.Bg3 The bishop moves from f4 to g3.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -3 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Absolute pin: pawn on g7.